Give Your AI a Memory

The Obsidian Method

> *A step-by-step guide to giving Claude a permanent, organised workspace on your Mac. No technical background needed. One evening to set up. Compounds forever.*

Every time you open a fresh Claude chat, you re-explain who you are, what you do, and what you are working on. Again.

This guide fixes that. You will set up a single folder on your Mac that Claude can read from and write to. The more you use it, the smarter it gets. Not because the AI improves, but because it has more of your thinking to work with.

What you will get

- The problem with scattered notes and AI amnesia, clearly explained
- What Obsidian is and why it is the right tool for this job
- Step-by-step Mac install with screenshots
- How to connect Claude to your vault using Cowork
- The one habit that makes the whole system compound
- Bonus: Installing Excalidraw for visual thinking

Your AI has amnesia

You had a brilliant conversation with ChatGPT three weeks ago. You worked through a problem, got a genuinely useful answer, refined it over several messages. It was some of the best thinking you have done in months.

Now you cannot find it.

Maybe you have since switched to Claude. Maybe the conversation is buried under a hundred others. Maybe you remember roughly what it said but not the exact wording. Either way, the thinking is gone and you are starting from scratch.

Sound familiar? Here is the rest of the picture:

- Your personal notes are in Apple Notes.
- Client documents live in Google Drive.
- Research is in downloaded PDFs you have never reopened.
- A half-finished blog post is in a Word file on your Desktop.
- Screenshots are in a folder called *Screenshots 2*.
- Meeting notes are in an email you sent yourself.

None of these things know the others exist. Mac, Google, and Microsoft do not play nicely together. You spend more time hunting for files than thinking about them.

And every time you open a fresh Claude chat, you re-explain who you are, what you do, and what you are working on. Again.

> **The problem is not your tools. The problem is that nothing talks to anything else, and your AI starts from zero every single time you open it.**

This guide fixes that.

What you actually need

Three things. In plain English:

1. One place to keep everything worth remembering.

Your notes, saved conversations, research, files, documents. All in one folder on your Mac. Not spread across five apps that do not talk to each other.

2. A format your AI can actually read.

So next time you ask Claude a question, it already has context. It knows what you are working on, what you have already figured out, and what matters to you. No re-explaining.

3. A habit of saving things back.

So the more you use it, the smarter the whole system gets. Your knowledge compounds. Everyone else's stays flat.

The unfair advantage nobody talks about

Most people use AI as a one-shot answer machine: ask a question, get a response, close the tab, forget it ever happened.

If instead you give Claude somewhere to **put its answers**, something changes. Next week's question starts from a richer place than today's. The week after that, richer still.

This is the difference between having a tool and having an assistant.
The good news: you do not need to buy anything or learn anything complicated. You need a folder, a viewer for that folder, and one daily habit.

Meet Obsidian

Obsidian is a free app for Mac that opens a folder on your computer and lets you read, write, and browse the text files inside it.

That is genuinely the whole app. It is a viewer for a folder of text files.

Your files stay on your machine. There is no cloud database. There is no account to create. There is no subscription to sign up for. If Obsidian disappeared tomorrow, your files would still be sitting in a folder on your Mac, completely readable.

Why that matters for what we are building: Claude can read and write those same files directly. Anything you or Claude saves into the folder appears in Obsidian immediately. Anything you write in Obsidian is instantly available to Claude. They are both looking at the same folder.

Nothing else in the notes-app world works quite like this:

	NOTION	APPLE NOTES	GOOGLE DOCS	OBSIDIAN
Files stay on your Mac	No	No	No	**Yes**
AI can read and write them	Limited	No	Limited	**Yes**
You own the format forever	No	No	No	**Yes**
Free to use	Partly	Yes	Partly	**Yes**

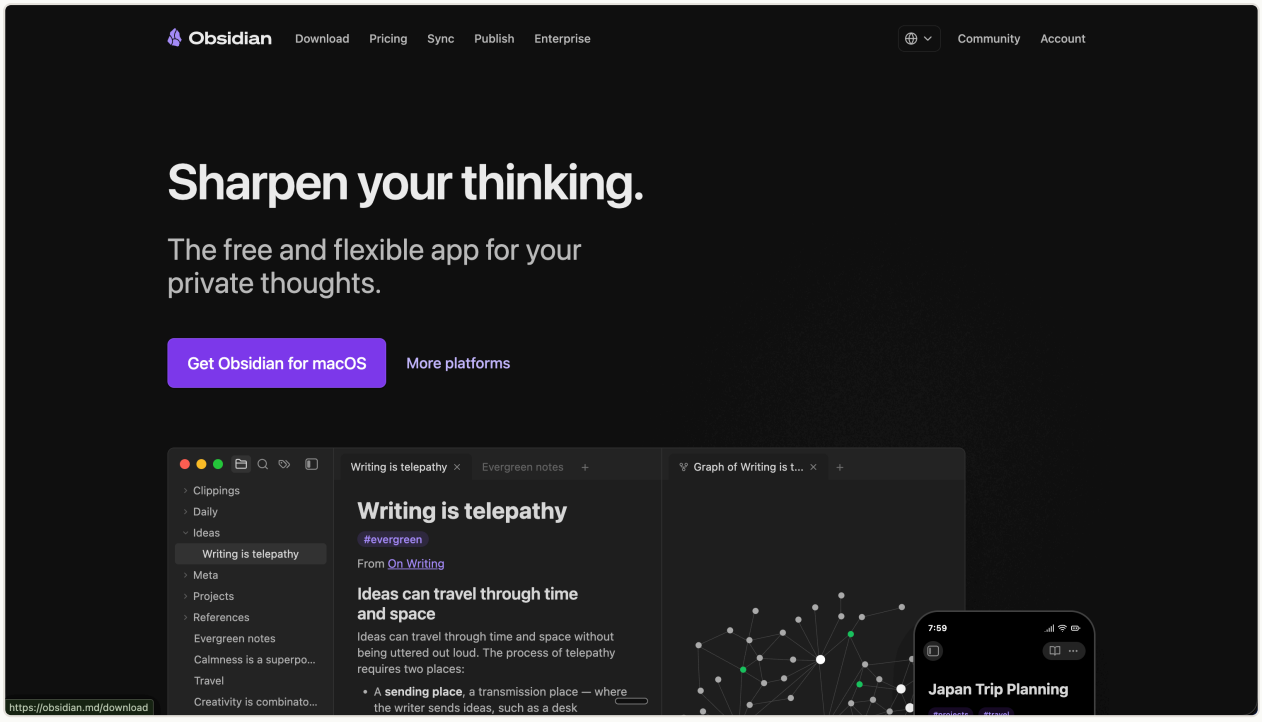
A note on pricing: Obsidian is free for personal use. They sell optional add-ons (Sync for cross-device access, Publish for public websites) but you do not need either for anything in this guide.

Obsidian also has a visual "graph view" that shows how your notes connect. It is fun to look at. It is not why we are here. Ignore it for now.

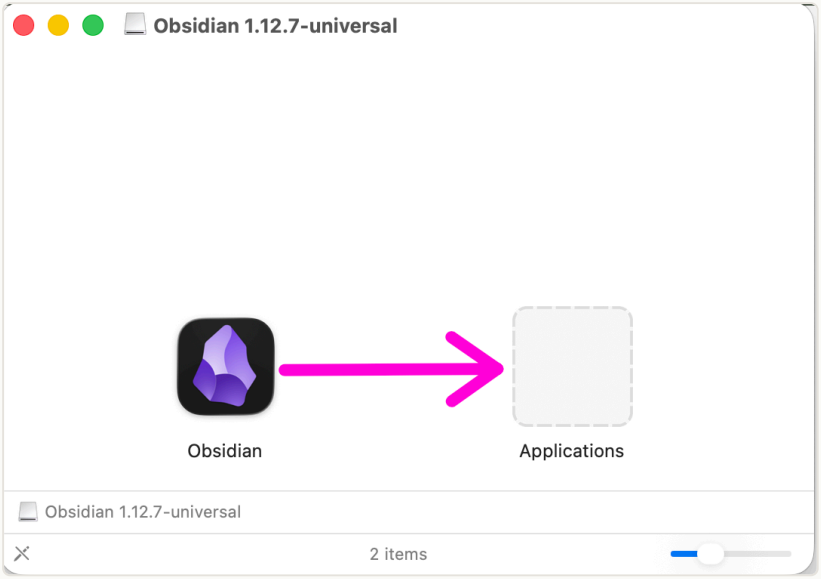
Install Obsidian on your Mac

This takes about two minutes.

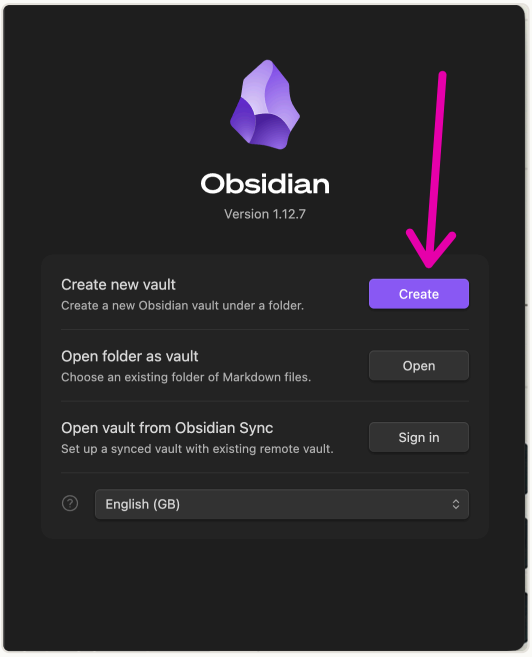
Step 1. Go to **obsidian.md** in your browser.



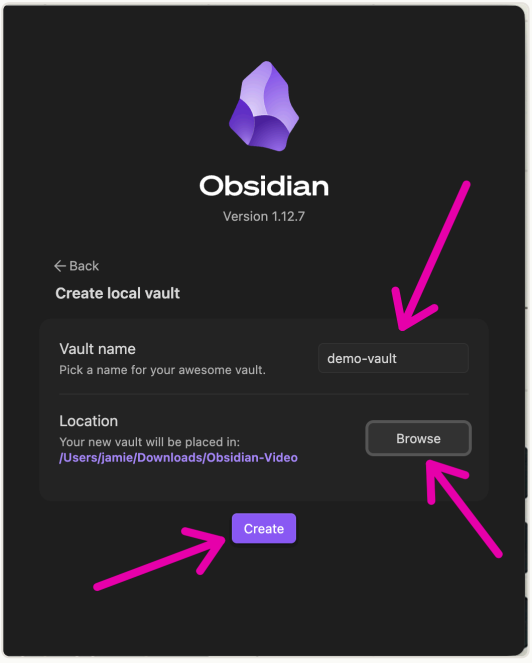
Step 2. Download the Mac version. When the download finishes, open the `.dmg` file and drag Obsidian into your Applications folder.



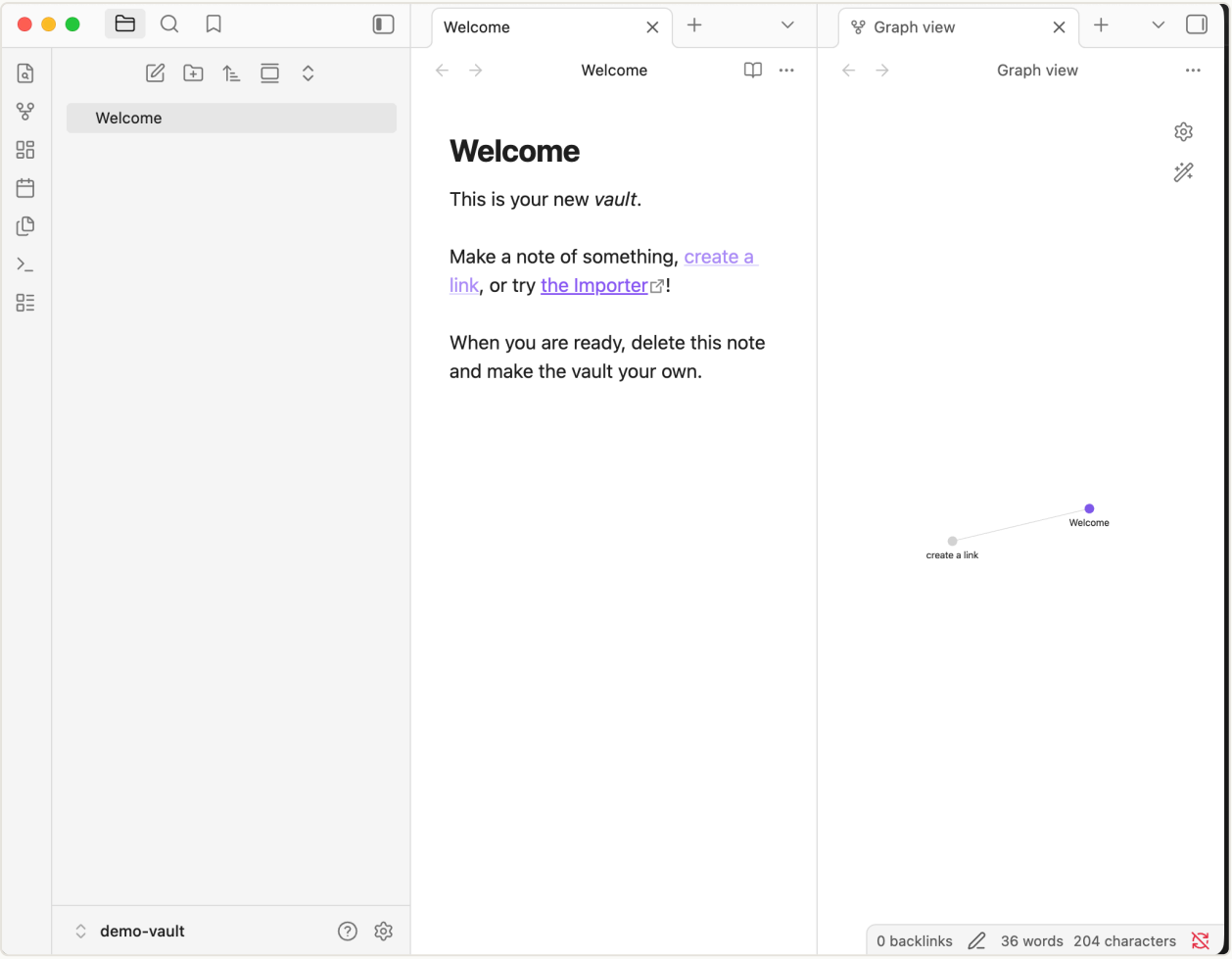
Step 3. Open Obsidian. On first launch, you will see an option to "Create new vault." Click **Create**.



Step 4. Name your vault something you will remember. Choose where to save it. Your Documents folder is fine.



Step 5. Open the vault. You will see an empty window with a Welcome note.



That is it. You now have an empty vault. It looks boring and empty. That is correct.

Now we need to connect Claude so it can see this folder and start working with it.

Connect Claude to your vault

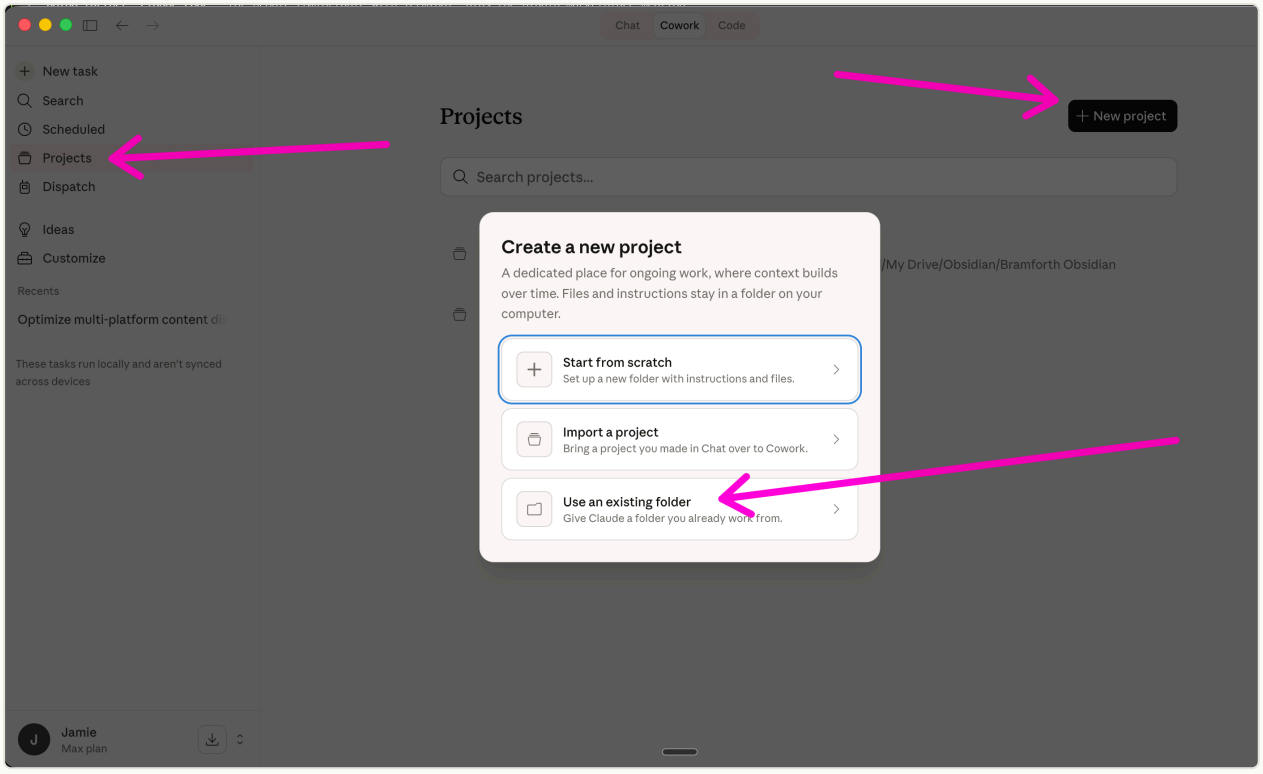
Before Claude can organise anything, it needs to be able to see your vault. The good news: this is simpler than you might expect.

The easy path: open your vault in Claude

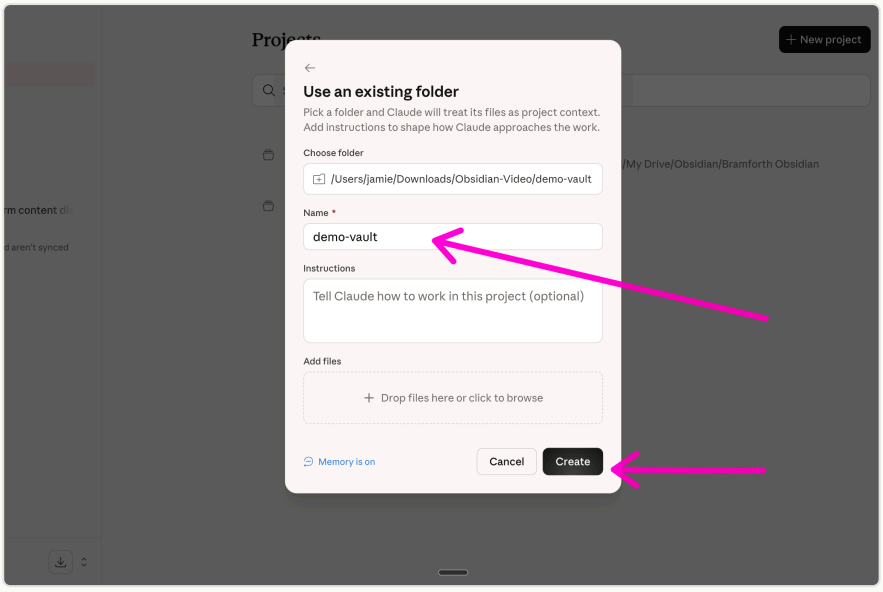
If you have the Claude Desktop app, you can use its **Cowork** feature. Cowork lets Claude see and work with files in a folder on your Mac, which is exactly what we need.

Step 1. Download Claude Desktop from **claude.ai/download** if you have not already. You will need a Claude Pro or Max subscription.

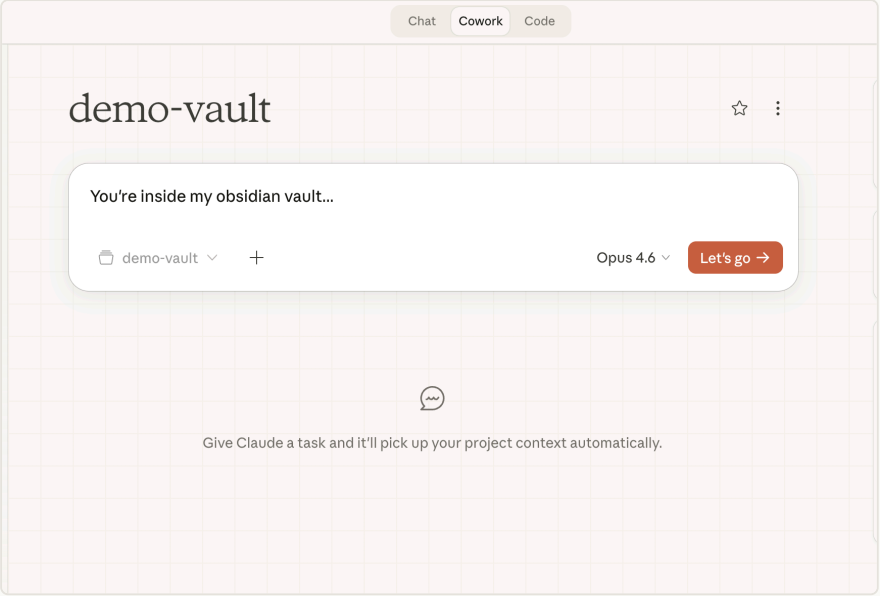
Step 2. Open Claude Desktop. Go to **Projects** in the left sidebar, click **New project**, then choose **"Use an existing folder"**.



Step 3. Point it at your vault folder (the one you created in the previous section). Give the project a name and click **Create**.



That is it. Claude can now read every file in your vault, create new files, and organise things on your behalf. No configuration files. No terminal commands. You just talk to it.



Going further: Claude Code

If you are comfortable with Terminal, Claude Code is a more powerful option. It runs directly inside your vault folder, can work across many files at once, and does not need any setup beyond installing it.

Quick start:

1. Open Terminal and install Claude Code from **claude.ai/code**
2. Navigate to your vault: `cd ~/Documents/My-AI-Vault`
3. Type `claude` and start talking.

> **Bonus:** Claude Code has a plugin marketplace with community-built skills and tools. Type `/plugin`, add the **jamieoarton/skills** marketplace, then browse and install anything useful. The **content-creation** plugin is a good starting point.

What about ChatGPT?

Honest answer: ChatGPT cannot connect to a folder on your Mac. You can upload files one at a time through the chat interface, but it cannot save anything back. You will be copy-pasting manually in both directions.

If you are serious about building a knowledge base that compounds, Claude is the tool for this job.

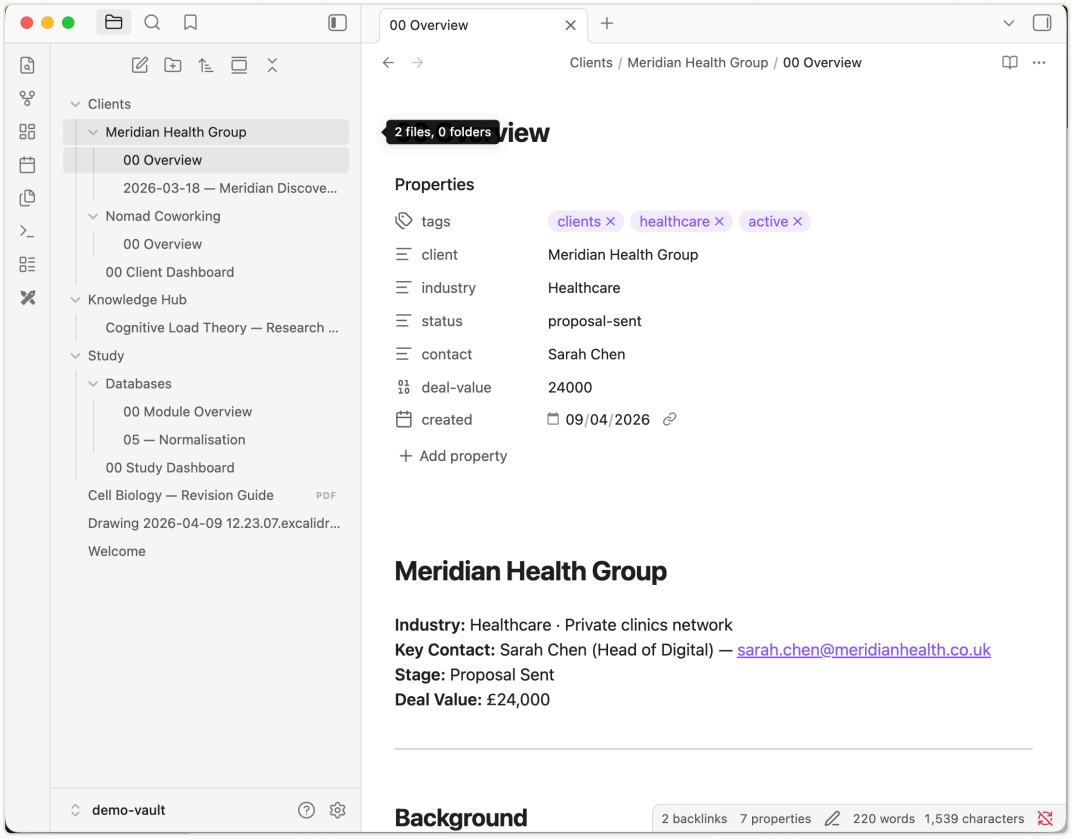
One alternative worth knowing about: Obsidian has a community plugin called **Copilot** that adds an AI chatbot directly inside Obsidian. It is useful for quick questions about the note you are currently looking at, but it cannot work across your whole vault the way Claude can. Think of it as a helpful extra, not a replacement.

Let Claude set up your vault

Here is where the shift happens. Instead of manually creating folders and moving things around, you are going to ask Claude to do it.

Open Claude (using whichever connection method you set up in the previous section) and type something like this:

"I have just created an empty Obsidian vault. Set it up as my personal knowledge workspace. Create folders for an inbox, my own notes, source material I collect, and things you write for me. Add a README that explains how we will use this together. Keep it simple."
Claude will create the folder structure, write the README, and explain what goes where. You will see the files appear in Obsidian's sidebar as Claude works.



This is the mindset shift the whole guide is really about.

You did not right-click, create folders, name them, or type a README. You described what you wanted in plain English and Claude handled it. That is how everything in this system works from now on.

The habit that makes it compound

There is only one discipline you need, and it is this:

Save everything back into the vault.
Let Claude file it.

When you finish a conversation with Claude and there is something worth keeping, say:

"Save that as a note in my vault, wherever it makes sense."
That is it. You do not need to decide where it goes. You do not need to name it. You do not need to organise anything. Claude decides. Sometimes it will get it wrong. That is fine. Tell it, and it will move things.

Do not open Obsidian to tidy things up. Do not manually rearrange folders. Do not worry about tags or categories or a perfect system. Just keep feeding the vault and let Claude keep it organised.

Here is what happens

Week one: Your vault has five files. Claude's answers are slightly better than before, but not dramatically.

Week four: Your vault has fifty files. Claude starts referencing things you forgot you saved. Connections appear between notes you did not link yourself.

Week twelve: Your vault has two hundred files. Claude's first answer to any question is better than anything it could have given you on day one, because it is answering from *your* context, not its generic training.

You, specifically, become the most valuable part of the system. Not the tool. Not the AI. Your accumulated knowledge and decisions, organised and compounding.

Everyone else is still re-explaining themselves every morning.

What to feed your vault in week one

Do not overthink this. Here are five things you can move into your vault today:

1. **That ChatGPT or Claude conversation you keep wanting to find again.** Copy the text, paste it into a file in your vault, and tell Claude to file it. Done. It is searchable forever.

2. **Your rough meeting notes.** Drop them in. Tell Claude to summarise and file them. Now you have a searchable record of every meeting, not a pile of scribbles.

3. **PDFs you have downloaded and never read.** Put them in the vault and ask Claude to read and summarise them. You will finally know what is in that report from three months ago.

4. **An "About Me" document.** Write one page about yourself: what you do, what you are working on, what your goals are. This becomes the first thing Claude reads whenever it needs to understand who you are. Write it once. Update it when things change.

5. **Anything you would normally save to Apple Notes, a Google Doc, or an email to yourself.** Redirect it to the vault instead. Every piece you add makes the whole system smarter.

You are done

That is the whole system:

1. **One folder** on your Mac (viewed through Obsidian).
2. **Claude connected** so it can read and write to that folder.
3. **One habit:** save everything back in, and let Claude organise it.

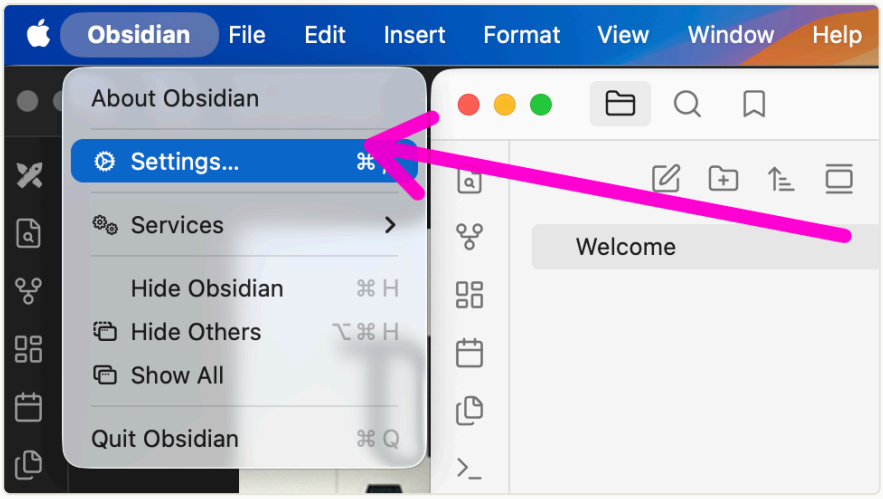
The more you use it, the better it gets. Not because the AI improves, but because it has more of your thinking to work with.

Bonus: Excalidraw for visual thinkers

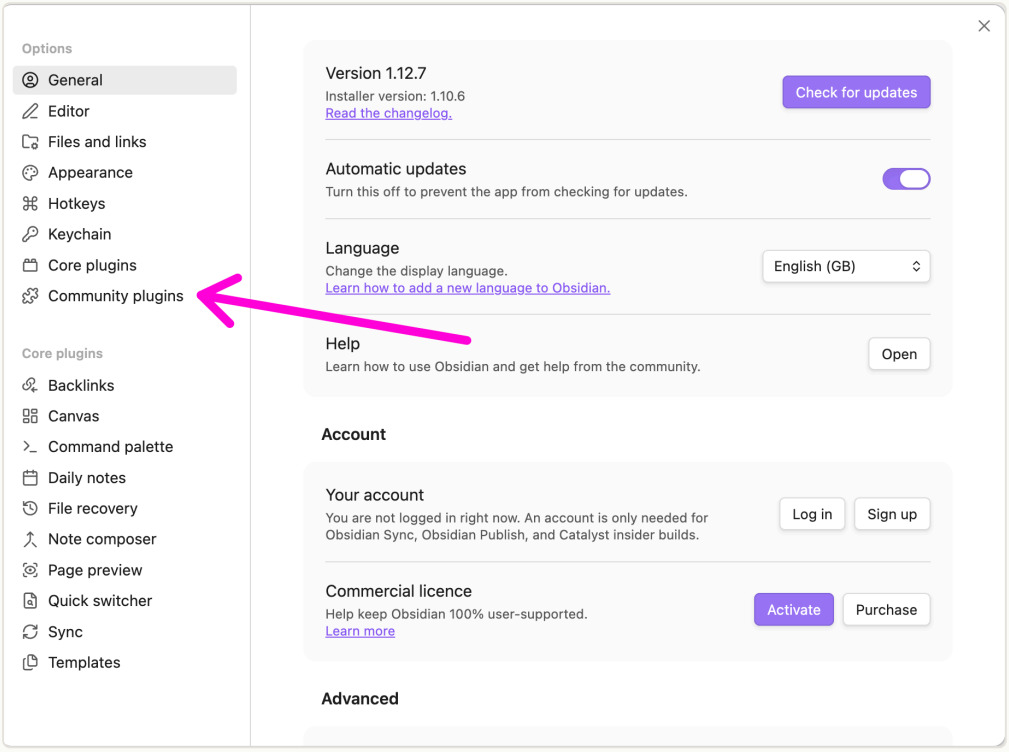
If you think in diagrams, flowcharts, or sketches rather than bullet points, there is one Obsidian plugin worth installing straight away.

Excalidraw is a free community plugin that gives you a full drawing canvas inside your vault. You can sketch ideas, map out processes, link drawings to your notes, and keep everything in the same place Claude can see it.

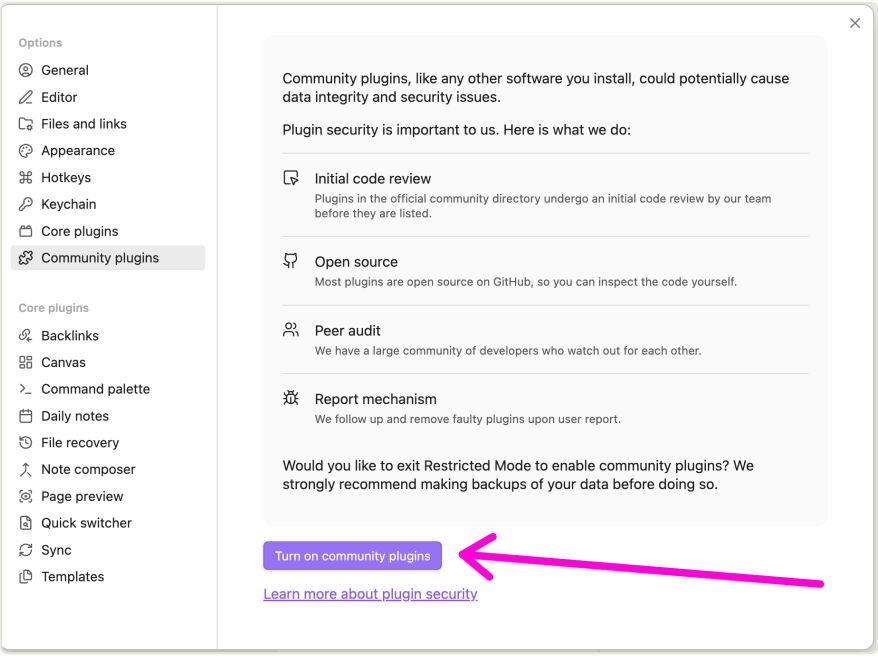
Step 1. Open Obsidian and go to **Settings** (Obsidian menu, or press ⌘ ,).



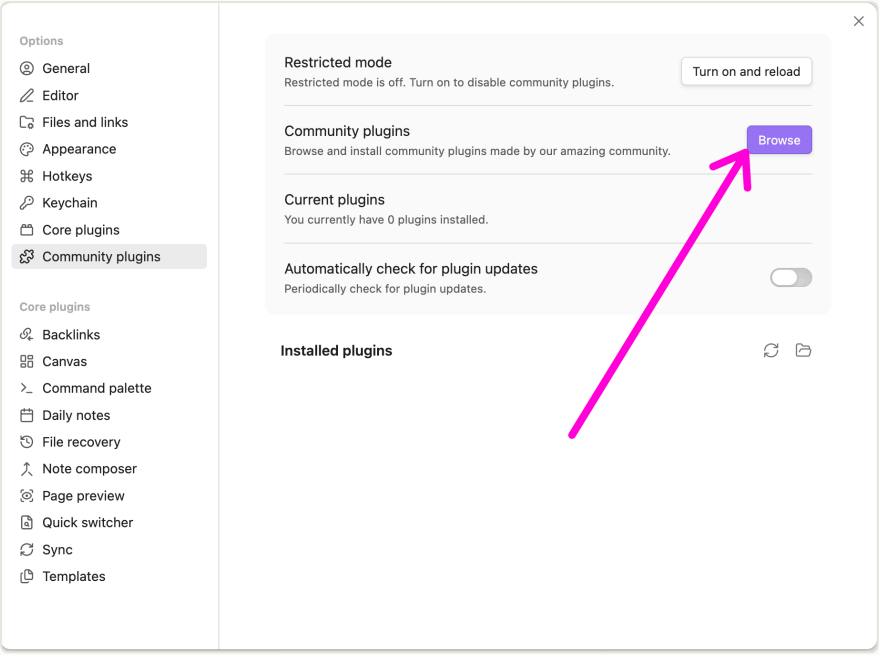
Step 2. In the left sidebar, click **Community plugins**.



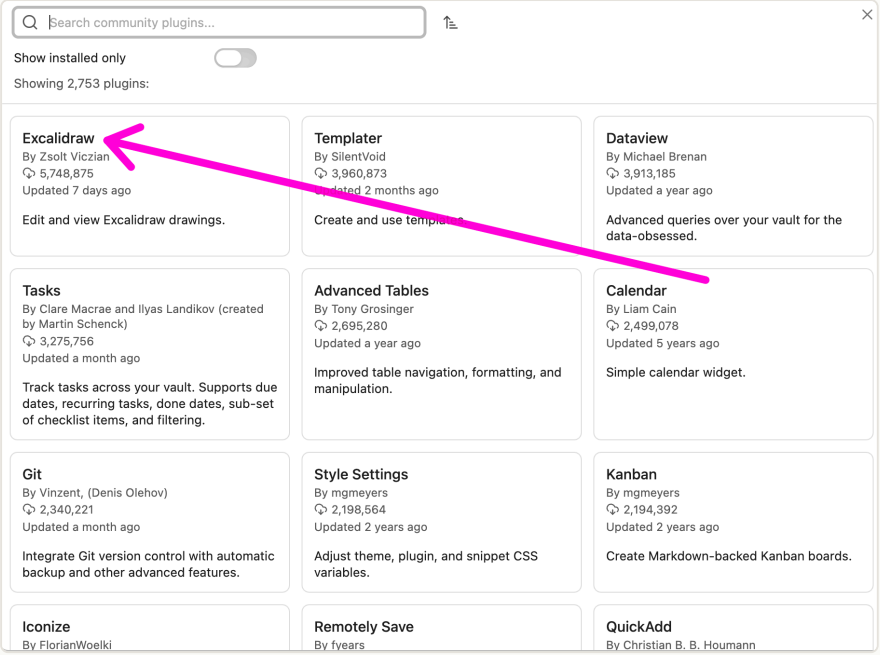
Step 3. You will see a message about Restricted Mode. Click **Turn on community plugins**. This is safe. Obsidian's community plugins are open source and code-reviewed.



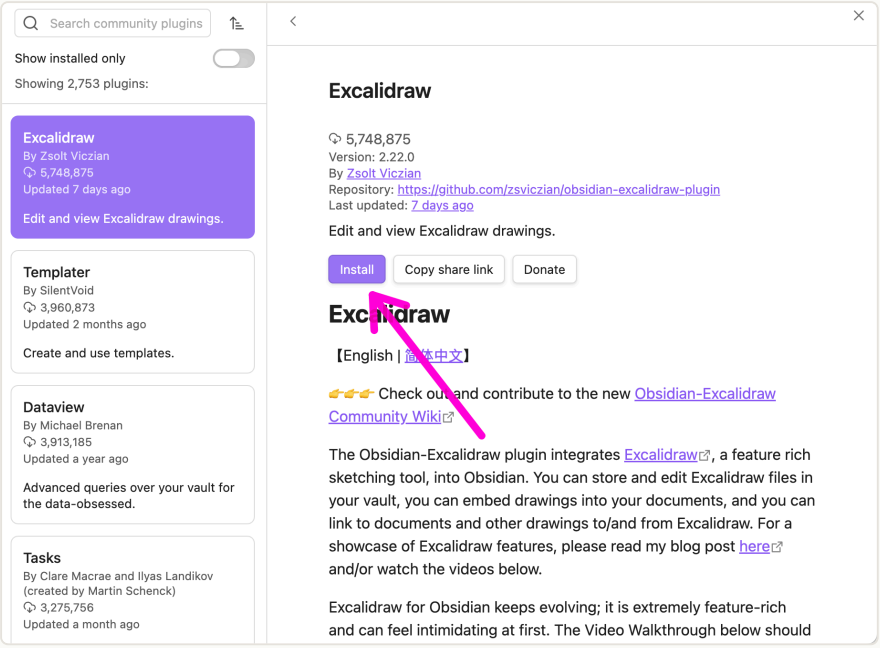
Step 4. Click **Browse** to open the plugin directory.



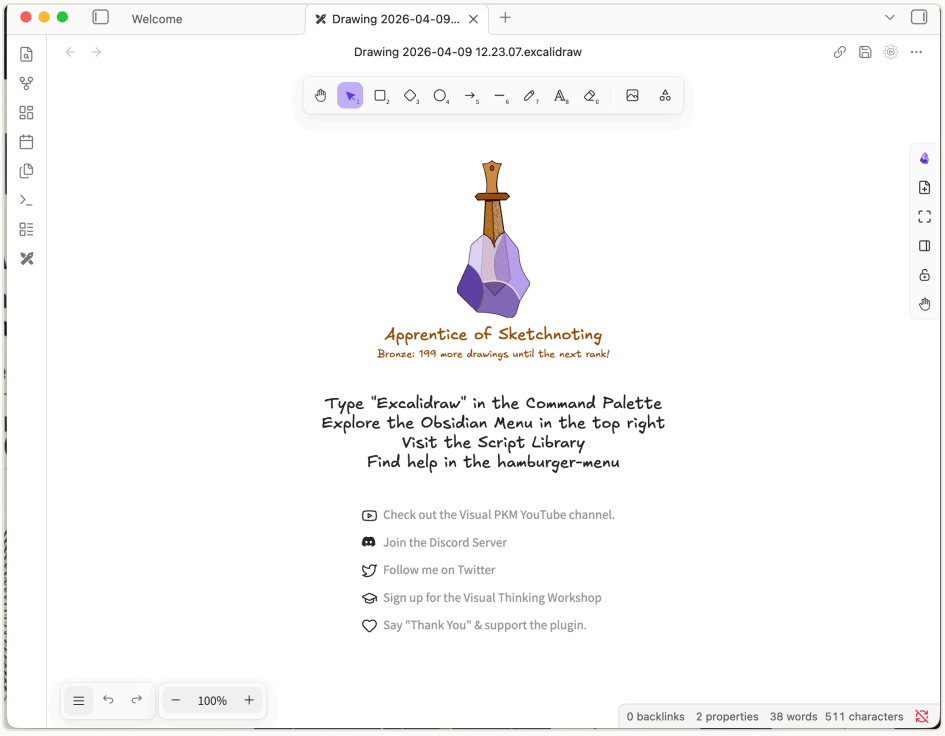
Step 5. Search for "Excalidraw." It will be the first result (it is the most popular plugin in the directory, with over 5.7 million downloads). Click on it.



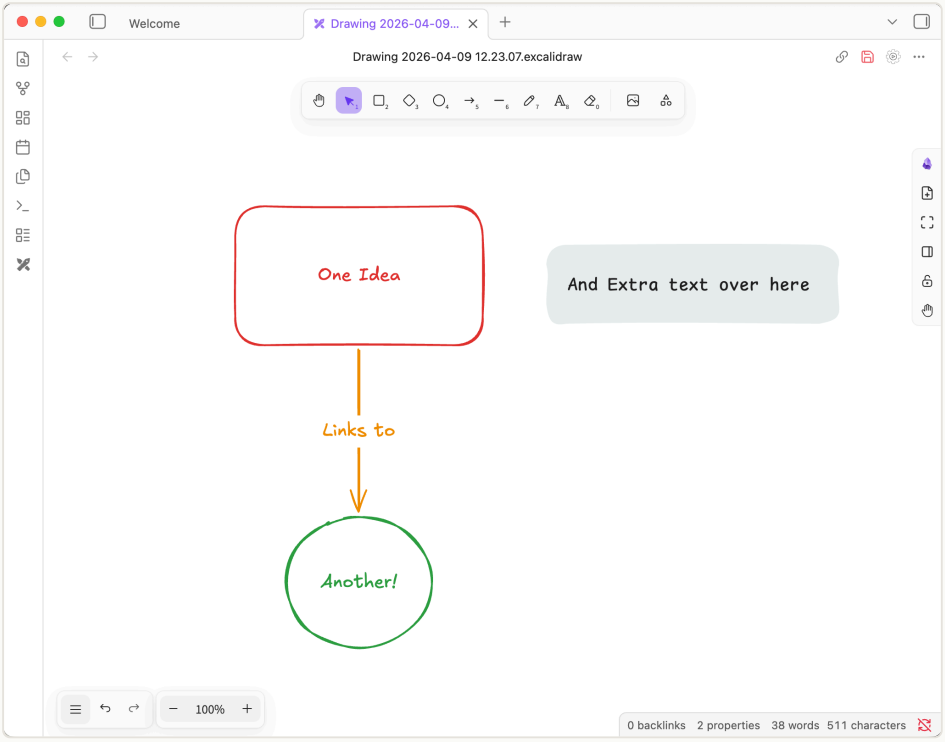
Step 6. Click **Install**.



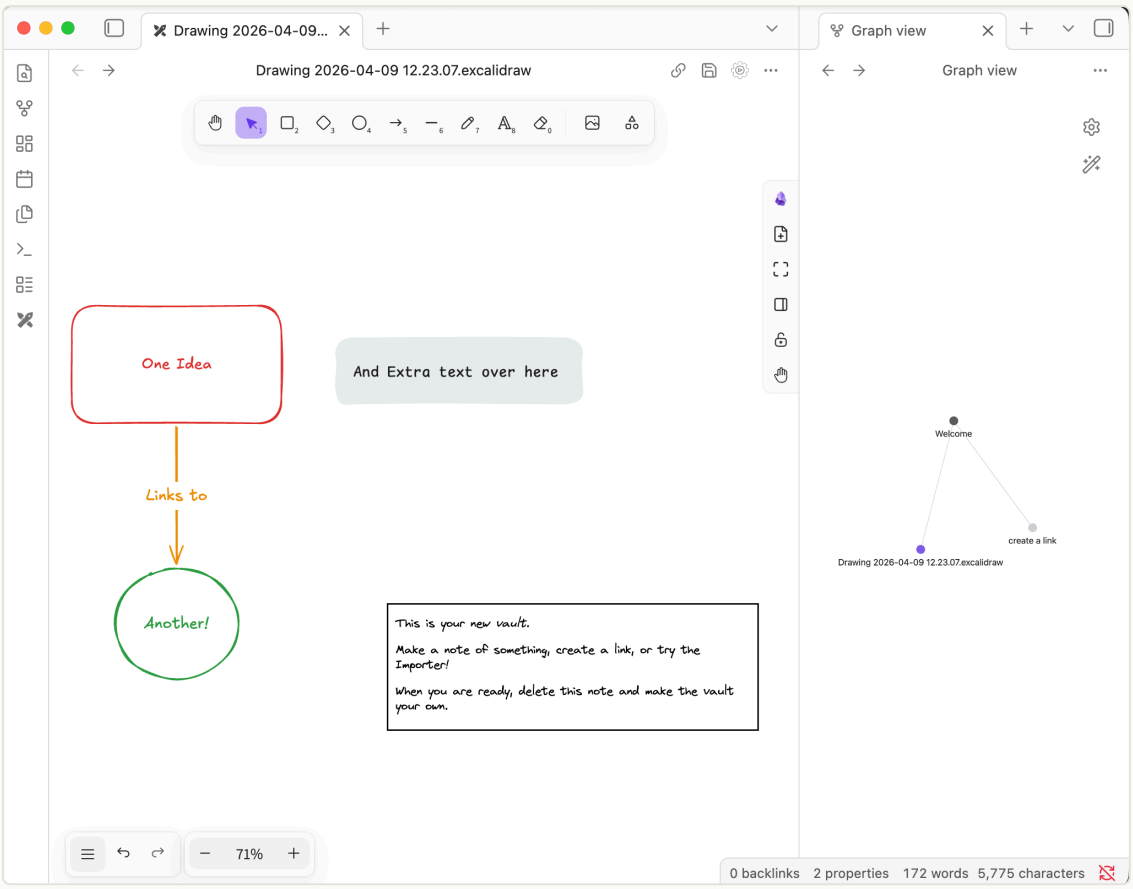
Step 7. Once installed, enable the plugin. Then open the Command Palette (press ⌘ P) and type "Excalidraw" to create your first drawing.



You now have a whiteboard inside your vault. Sketch ideas, map connections, plan projects.



Everything you draw is saved as a file in your vault, which means Claude can see it too.



This is entirely optional. The core system works without it. But if you are the kind of person who reaches for a pen and paper when thinking through a problem, Excalidraw replaces that paper with something searchable, linkable, and permanent.

Join the community

If this guide was useful, come and join **AI Freedom Finders**, a free community of people building exactly this kind of workflow with AI. We share setups, frameworks, prompts, and honest reviews of what is actually working.

skool.com/ai-freedom-finders

About the Author

Jamie Oarton is a fractional Chief AI Officer through Bramforth AI, helping UK mid-market companies (£20M to £100M revenue) build AI strategies that actually connect to how they make money.

He has advised on AI strategy at the highest levels of UK government, military, and diplomatic services, and has delivered AI training to senior British Army officers.

Jamie works with companies that know AI matters but do not have a plan, building strategy, setting governance, and making sure AI investments deliver measurable results rather than expensive experiments.

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EMAIL
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